

Prophet

Western versus South Plantation—the most anticipated season opener of the 2023-2024 season. At center court, the referee tosses the ball straight up in the air. Maddox wins the tip for us. Stefan secures possession of the ball and quickly advances it to Ethan, running the break on the left wing. Ethan finds me cutting toward the basket from the right side. A perfect pass. A play that we had executed to perfection multiple times before.

But not this time. I miss the layup. There was nobody near me. Not a single hand in sight to contest my shot. It was just surprisingly poor communication between three longtime friends: me, the ball, and the backboard.

In shame, I watch the ball as it rolls off the backboard. Number 0 on South Plantation grabs the rebound off the front iron. In frustration, I decide to pick him up on defense full court. The whole 94 feet. We are tussling. There is a lot of hand-checking both ways. About 7 seconds later, he makes it past half-court. He found an open man in the right corner. The shot quickly goes up.

But I watch the ball move in slow motion. As it floats through the air, it only gets slower. The players around me froze. The crowd fell silent. It was like the ball wanted to be seen. It was sending me a message, but I wasn't ready to understand it.

Splash. Straight through the net. And just like that: 3-0.

I turn around, jogging back up the court, trying to shift my mentality to the next play. At half court, I fall to my knees. Confused, I quickly get back up.

Seventeen minutes later, my eyes open to a beaming bright light above me. I lie horizontal, parallel to the court's surface. I realize that I never actually made it on my feet. There are no thoughts circulating through my head, but I know something is off. My wrists are being held down to the floor by my peers. My ankles—the same. I tilt my head slightly to the right and see a woman inches from my face.

She is talking to me. I think. Her mouth is moving. I can hear noise. But I am unable to make sense of what she is saying. I see her. I analyze every detail of her face. **But revelation without understanding is obsolete.** I fail to recognize that the woman is Camille—my teammate Javian's mother.

I don't recognize her. I don't recognize those who are restraining my movement. Instinctively, my aggression takes over. I break free. My fist connects directly with Camille's face. I immediately run away. **Little did I know, I was running away from my own heart.**

Nine minutes later, “your eyes open **again after the defibrillator shocks**”

I am forced to borrow other people's eyes. For the first time in my life, I lost control.

“They are bulging through your eye sockets. You reminded us of your strength after the first attack, so this time we prepare accordingly. We had fathers hold you down at each of your wrists and ankles. Coach Mike held down your torso area.

You try to break free again. But you fail. Again and again. You stand no chance this time around. And because of that, you are terrified. You have no idea where you are. You have no idea who anybody is.

Your skin is pale, but your face is tomato red. Your head begins to flail as you scream for your mom.”

No matter who tells the story, that part is always the same.

“You begged. But she refused to come over. She couldn’t witness her son suffering a second attack. But you continue to scream viscerally.”

To this day, I share this restoration with no recollection.

Five minutes later, my eyes opened once more. I feel a fan blowing directly in my face. The same light continues to beam directly in my eyes. I still lie horizontal, parallel to the court’s surface. My body, once again, is being restrained—but not by my peers.

I try to move my arm.

Nothing.

I try to move my leg.

Nothing.

I can’t move anything. I am trapped in my own body. But this entrapment gave me the awareness I needed. I once again see a woman a few inches away from my head.

It’s Camille. She’s a doctor. So my mind races as her hands lie on my chest. She tells me to calm down. It was not like I could move anyway. Moments later, I see the ambulance enter the gym. They hurry in their rugged, navy blue cargo pants. But I knew something was wrong.

I felt this sharp pain in my heart. It was not because of the attacks. It was not because of my inability to move. It was not because of the people who surrounded me in tears. It was not because of the ambulance arriving. It was the pain of knowing there is no more basketball. **Nobody needed to tell me that. No doctor. No coach. No peer. I finally received the message.**

Maybe that is what a prophet is. Someone cursed with seeing what comes next before anyone else does. That night, before the scans. Before the diagnosis. Before the conversations. Before the grief. I saw the end of one life and the beginning of another.

The ambulance crew finished preparing the stretcher. They lift me off the floor and begin rolling me toward the exit. As we move through the gym, I notice the crowd. Parents. Coaches. Teammates. Students. Everyone is staring, **as if they lost me.**

They did.

3 times.

Just 31 minutes ago, people were watching a basketball game. Now all eyes were on me.

As I passed through the exit doors, I entered a new chapter. An entirely different reality.

I was sold another life.

And I hope to return a profit.